

92 Hosea

The prophet whose broken marriage became a picture of God's faithful love.

Hosea prophesied to the northern kingdom of Israel in its last decades, from the prosperous days of Jeroboam II to the years before Samaria fell. God told him to marry Gomer and to give their children names that were messages to the nation. Gomer was unfaithful to him. Later God told him to love her again and buy her back. Hosea's home became a living sermon: Israel had run after other gods as an unfaithful wife runs after lovers, yet God would not let her go. His book is full of grief and anger, but also tenderness. "How shall I give thee up, Ephraim?" asks the LORD. Jesus twice quoted Hosea's message: "I will have mercy, and not sacrifice."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Hoshea</i> , "salvation"
Family	Son of Beeri; husband of Gomer, daughter of Diblaim (Hosea 1:1, 3)
Children	Jezreel, Lo-ruhamah and Lo-ammi (Hosea 1:4–9)
When	Days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah of Judah, and Jeroboam II of Israel, c. 755–715 BC (Hosea 1:1)
Audience	The northern kingdom, often called Ephraim
Main passages	Hosea 1–14
New Testament	Matthew 2:15; 9:13; 12:7; Romans 9:25–26; 1 Peter 2:10

"For I desired mercy, and not sacrifice; and the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings."

Hosea 6:6, KJV

The life of Hosea

Dates are approximate (BC). Hosea tells us almost nothing about his life apart from his marriage, and he does not date its events.

- c. 755 BC

Under Jeroboam II

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The call and the marriage

The word of the LORD comes to Hosea. God tells him to marry, and he takes Gomer as his wife, as a sign of Israel's unfaithfulness. *Hosea 1:1-3*
- The following years

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Three children named

A son is named Jezreel, for the bloodshed of Jehu's house. A daughter is named Lo-ruhamah, "not pitied." A son is named Lo-ammi, "not my people." *Hosea 1:3-9*
- Later

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Buys back his wife

God tells him to love a woman who has been unfaithful. He buys her for fifteen pieces of silver and some barley and asks her to be faithful to him. *Hosea 3:1-3*
- c. 750-725 BC

Israel in turmoil

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Warns a failing nation

Kings are murdered one after another, and Israel turns to Egypt and Assyria for help. Hosea calls this unfaithfulness to God. *Hosea 7:7-11; 8:4, 9*
- c. 722 BC

Fall of Samaria

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The warnings come true

Assyria captures Samaria and takes Israel into exile, as Hosea had warned. Scripture does not say whether he lived to see it. *Hosea 13:16; 2 Kings 17:5-6*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians have read Hosea's marriage in different ways. Some think Gomer was already unfaithful when Hosea married her. Others think she became unfaithful later and the story is told looking back. Most think the woman in chapter 3 is Gomer, though the text does not name her.

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Obedied a hard command. He married Gomer as God told him, knowing his marriage would carry a message. *Hosea 1:2-3*
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- 2

Named his children as signs. Their names warned Israel of judgment. God then promised to reverse them: "Ye are the sons of the living God." *Hosea 1:4-10; 2:23*
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Spoke of God as a husband. God promised to win Israel back and said, "I will betroth thee unto me for ever." *Hosea 2:14-20*
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- 4

Loved his wife again. He bought her back and waited for her, a picture of God waiting for Israel. *Hosea 3:1-5*
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- 5

Accused the priests. "My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge," he said, because the priests had rejected knowledge. *Hosea 4:1-9*
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- 6

Named Israel's folly. He warned that those who sow the wind will reap the whirlwind. *Hosea 7:11; 8:7*
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- 7

Showed God's heart. God had loved Israel as a child and called his son out of Egypt, and could not give Ephraim up. *Hosea 11:1-9*
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- 8

Called Israel home. He ended with an invitation: "O Israel, return unto the LORD thy God," and God's promise, "I will heal their backsliding." *Hosea 14:1-4*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Hosea.

Old Testament

Hosea 1–14	The book of his marriage and prophecies
2 Kings 14:23–17:23	Israel's last kings and the fall of Samaria
Echo: Jeremiah 3:1–14; Ezekiel 16	God's people as an unfaithful wife

New Testament

Matthew 9:13; 12:7	Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6: "I will have mercy, and not sacrifice"
Matthew 2:15	"Out of Egypt have I called my son" applied to Jesus
Romans 9:25–26; 1 Peter 2:10	"Not my people" become God's people
1 Corinthians 15:55	Paul's cry over death echoes Hosea 13:14
Luke 23:30; Revelation 6:16	Calling on the mountains, as in Hosea 10:8
Echo: Ephesians 5:25–27; Revelation 19:7	The church as Christ's bride

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Hosea do in Hosea 3:1–3, and what did it cost him?
- Understand:* Why do you think God chose a marriage to picture his bond with his people?
- Apply:* God wants mercy more than routine (Hosea 6:6). Where has your faith become routine?
- Apply:* Whom do you need to keep loving though they hurt you? What is one step you could take?